Yet by the time Admiral Harry Harris made his claim, the nature of the US-China relationship was shifting steadily from cooperation toward confrontation. Years of bilateral engagement over political, economic, and security issues appeared irrelevant in the face of China's massive growth in power and influence, much of which seemed aimed squarely at reducing America's role in the Indo-Pacific region. Watching the slowly gathering storm clouds were Asian nations large and small, some of which were US allies, most of which had ties with the United States, and all of which viewed China's rise with a mixture of opportunism and wariness.

Hegemony, however, was a particularly loaded term. The goal of US security policy since 1945 has been to prevent the rise of an aggressive hegemon in either Asia or Europe. To label China as such was tantamount to declaring it a threat to US interests and regional stability alike. For its part, Beijing had for years denied any hegemonic ambitions, imputing such aims instead to the United States; to be so called out by America's senior military leader in the Indo-Pacific revealed the dawn of a new era in relations between the two nations.

Until Harris's statement, US officials had more often than not downplayed China's increasingly assertive military tendencies during the second decade of the twenty-first century. Such an approach was not new in Sino-American relations. In similar ways, American policy makers had quietly moved to restore relations that were briefly interrupted after the 1989 Tiananmen Square massacre, had largely ignored credible evidence that China had stolen top-secret nuclear missile technology from the United States during the 1990s, and had no response to China's rampant industrial espionage in the 2000s and beyond.[3] The default position of the US government for decades had been to try and ignore offensive or threatening Chinese behavior and instead redouble its efforts to reach accommodation with Beijing.

By the time of Harris's testimony, the question of whether decades of US military dominance in the Indo-Pacific region would continue was openly being discussed by allies and antagonists alike. Not merely